



KRISHNARAJE RAJEMAHADIK (ABOVE) TRACES HIS LINEAGE TO SHIVAJI'S ELDEST SON-IN-LAW HARJIRAJE RAJEMAHADIK. SHILSINH IS ONE OF THE FEW WHO STILL POSSESS ANCIENT MARATHA WEAPONS USED BY THEIR FOREFATHERS.



MARATHA GENERAL KANHOJI NAIK JEDHE'S DESCENDANT BALASAHEB JEDHE (LEFT) IS A FARMER WHO LIVES FRUGALLY IN HIS CRUMBLING HAVELI NEAR PUNE

Khanderao, led the Maratha army and won a battle against the Mughals near Ahmedabad.

The most well-preserved heirlooms are perhaps with Krishnaraje Rajemahadik and his father Shilsinhraje, descendants of Shivaji's eldest son-in-law Harjiraje Rajemahadik. Their haveli in Tarale village near Satara houses swords, daggers, spears, silverware and ancient covered cars used by women to travel. Shivaji had visited Tarale for his daughter Ambicabai's wedding. "It is difficult to maintain old articles but our love for tradition has enabled us to do so. That our family was so closely related to Shivaji and fought bravely for him is a source of inspiration," says Krishnaraje.

There are some who are not so fortunate. Balkrishna Sapkal, a descendant of Jiva Mahadik, is paralysed and poverty-struck. A barber, he can no longer work. But his pride is intact. Shorn of his ancestral land and mansion in village Kondivli, Sapkal lives with his wife Suman in a 10-by-8 rented room near Kondivli. Local politicians associated with royalty took away his documents and an inscribed copper plate that established his ancestry. "As a dignified descendant of such a brave man, I don't like to beg. But I would be happy if the government or some descendants of Shivaji did something for us," he says.

Sapkal is not alone. Balasaheb Jedhe traces his lineage to Kanhoji Jedhe, the Jagirdar of Karli near Pune. Kanhoji supported Shivaji with 22 chieftains and soldiers in the battle against Afzal Khan. In the battle of Yelburga in 1677, Kanhoji's son Nagoji severed the trunk of the elephant on which Bijapuri general Hussain Khan Miyana was riding before being shot dead. Today, Jedhe and his four brothers share 70 acres of land and a dilapidated haveli. The only inheritance that remains is Kanhoji's 400-year-old armour and copper idols of gods and goddesses, including a Shivling brought by Kanhoji from Karnataka.

Jedhe is a farmer but he still commands respect for his family's place in history. The Jedhe family's old family papers helped historians like Jadynath Sarkar in their research on Maratha history. "Old families among us who are well-off don't need help from the government like we do. Some provisions must be made for hard-up families like ours considering the sacrifices made by our ancestors," laments Jedhe.

Almost four centuries after Shivaji and his brave warriors kept Emperor Aurangzeb's armies from ravaging Maharashtra, their descendants have only their near-forgotten pride and heirlooms to nourish. Sadly, their ancestors' rightful place in history still eludes them.